

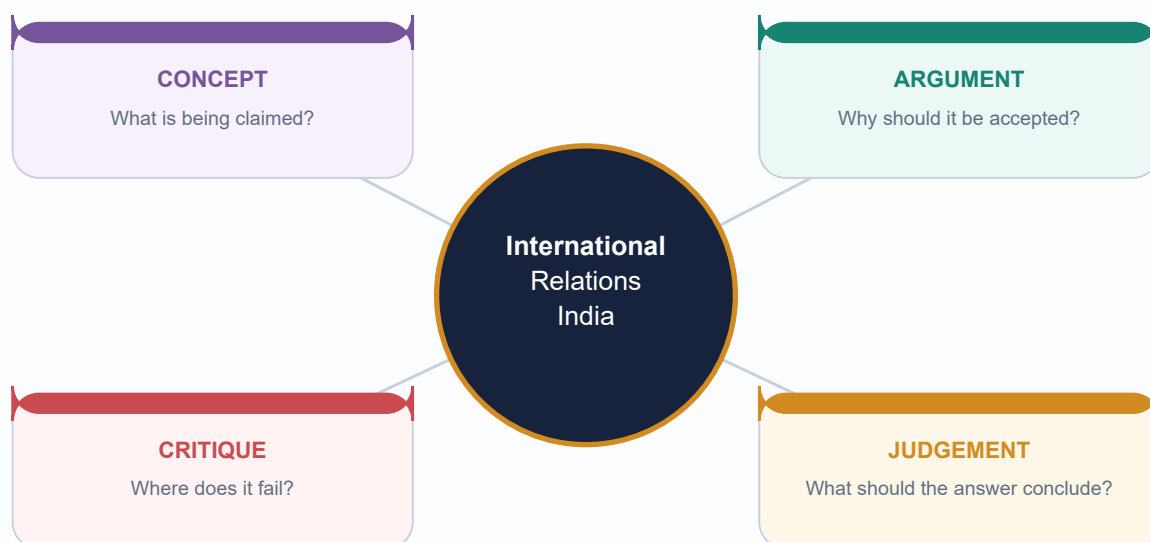
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

International Relations 02 - India and the Neighbourhood - Solved Practice Workbook

Current-affairs freeze: 15 August 2026

8 locally routed PYQs/applications | 28 MCQs | 7 solved Mains questions

Generated; awaiting explicit approval



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

PYQ 1. M2022-9 - Mains

GS-II / Prelims

International

Relations

NEWS TRIGGER

True owner: IR Topic 02 | Format: 10 marks / 150 words

INTRO & ORIGIN

India is an age-old friend of Sri Lanka. Discuss India's role in the recent crisis in Sri Lanka in the light of the preceding statement.

STATIC THEORY

- Claim: India translated historical proximity into first-responder capacity during Sri Lanka's 2022 economic crisis. Evidence: by 3 May 2022, India's High Commission recorded more than USD 3 billion through an essentials facility, petroleum credit, Asian Clearing Union deferment and an RBI currency swap; full-year official descriptions commonly place support near USD 4 billion. Mechanism and significance: fuel, food, medicines, payment relief and currency support protected basic availability and macroeconomic space when market access had collapsed. The assistance also demonstrated that Neighbourhood First can provide rapid public goods rather than only diplomatic rhetoric. Qualification: emergency finance could not repair Sri Lanka's structural fiscal, debt, revenue and governance problems; recovery required domestic adjustment and an IMF-supported programme. India also had to remain sensitive to Sri Lankan sovereignty, Tamil reconciliation and fishermen concerns. Verdict: India's role was consequential because it combined speed, scale and multiple instruments, but friendship earns durable credibility only when crisis response is followed by transparent, locally owned development cooperation.

- Why this earns marks: the solution preserves ownership and key status, uses named evidence, explains significance, adds a limitation and gives a defensible conclusion or elimination route.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Historical demand preserved.
2. Current anchors do not replace the question.
3. Official, inferred and provisional key status are distinguished.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Force ownership into Topic 02.

CORRECT: Retain owner: IR Topic 02.

MAINS ANGLE

Revise the demand word, evidence density and status caution before writing.

STUDY LINK

Main package country/regional modules.

HIGH

PYQ 2. M2022-10 - Mains

GS-II / Prelims

International

Relations

NEWS TRIGGER

True owner: IR Topic 10; included here as regional application | Format: 10 marks / 150 words

INTRO & ORIGIN

Do you think that BIMSTEC is a parallel organisation like the SAARC? What are the similarities and dissimilarities between the two? How are Indian foreign policy objectives realised by forming this new organisation?

STATIC THEORY

- Claim: BIMSTEC is not simply a parallel SAARC; it is an overlapping Bay of Bengal organisation with a different geography and functional logic. Evidence: SAARC contains the eight South Asian states and works by consensus; BIMSTEC has seven members linking South and Southeast Asia and its Charter entered into force on 20 May 2024. Similarity: both pursue regional cooperation, connectivity and development and include several of India's neighbours. Difference and mechanism: BIMSTEC excludes Pakistan, includes Myanmar and Thailand, and links Neighbourhood First with Act East and maritime interests. The Maritime Transport Cooperation Agreement entered into force on 16 May 2026 only among the four ratifying parties then recorded, illustrating variable legal implementation rather than automatic region-wide delivery. Qualification: BIMSTEC cannot substitute for all-South-Asia cooperation and remains vulnerable to capacity and political delays. Verdict: it diversifies India's regional instruments but succeeds only through implemented projects, not institutional comparison alone.

- Why this earns marks: the solution preserves ownership and key status, uses named evidence, explains significance, adds a limitation and gives a defensible conclusion or elimination route.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Historical demand preserved.
2. Current anchors do not replace the question.
3. Official, inferred and provisional key status are distinguished.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Force ownership into Topic 02.

CORRECT: Retain owner: IR Topic 10; included here as regional application.

MAINS ANGLE

Revise the demand word, evidence density and status caution before writing.

STUDY LINK

Main package country/regional modules.

HIGH**PYQ 3. M2024-20 - Mains**

GS-II / Prelims
International
Relations

NEWS TRIGGER

True owner: IR Topic 04; included here for Maldives module | Format: 15 marks / 250 words

INTRO & ORIGIN

Discuss the geopolitical and geostrategic importance of Maldives for India with a focus on global trade and energy flows. Further discuss how this relationship affects India's maritime security and regional stability amidst international competition.

STATIC THEORY

- Claim: Maldives matters because island geography near Indian Ocean routes combines trade, energy, security and political influence in one relationship. Evidence: India has repeatedly acted as first responder, including 1988 security assistance and the 2014 water crisis; the 7 October 2024 Joint Vision and July 2025 instruments widened economic and maritime cooperation. Mechanism: maritime-domain awareness, hydrography, training, disaster response and resilient island infrastructure help secure commercial routes and reduce the vulnerability of a dispersed archipelago. Development and health cooperation create local legitimacy for security partnership. International competition matters because Maldives diversifies finance and infrastructure partners, including China; India therefore competes through proximity, response speed and public goods. Qualification: sovereignty narratives and domestic political cycles mean cooperation must be requested and transparent. A Line of Credit is financing, not delivered infrastructure, and FTA Terms of Reference are not a concluded trade agreement. Verdict: Maldives is geostrategically important, but India's sustainable advantage comes from consent-based security and reliable development delivery rather than exclusivity.

- Why this earns marks: the solution preserves ownership and key status, uses named evidence, explains significance, adds a limitation and gives a defensible conclusion or elimination route.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Historical demand preserved.
2. Current anchors do not replace the question.
3. Official, inferred and provisional key status are distinguished.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Force ownership into Topic 02.**CORRECT:** Retain owner: IR Topic 04; included here for Maldives module.**MAINS ANGLE**

Revise the demand word, evidence density and status caution before writing.

STUDY LINK

Main package country/regional modules.

HIGH**PYQ 4. P2020-64 - Prelims****GS-II / Prelims**International
Relations**NEWS TRIGGER**

True owner: IR Topic 02 | Format: Objective

INTRO & ORIGIN

Consider the statements on India-Sri Lanka trade trends, textiles in India-Bangladesh trade, and Nepal as India's largest South Asian trading partner. Select the correct answer.

STATIC THEORY

- INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED IN THE LOCAL ROUTING LEDGER. The defensible elimination is that the Bangladesh textile statement is correct, while the absolute claims about a consistent decade-long rise and Nepal being the largest partner are unsafe. Confidence: medium. The workbook treats the item as a trade-fact verification exercise and does not label the inferred key official.

- Why this earns marks: the solution preserves ownership and key status, uses named evidence, explains significance, adds a limitation and gives a defensible conclusion or elimination route.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Historical demand preserved.
2. Current anchors do not replace the question.
3. Official, inferred and provisional key status are distinguished.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Force ownership into Topic 02.**CORRECT:** Retain owner: IR Topic 02.**MAINS ANGLE**

Revise the demand word, evidence density and status caution before writing.

STUDY LINK

Main package country/regional modules.

HIGH**PYQ 5. P2023-10 - Prelims****GS-II / Prelims**International
Relations**NEWS TRIGGER**

True owner: IR Topic 02 / Geography connectivity application | Format: Objective

INTRO & ORIGIN

With reference to India's connectivity projects, evaluate statements on the East-West Corridor, the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway and the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar Economic Corridor.

STATIC THEORY

- INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED IN THE LOCAL ROUTING LEDGER. Only one statement is correct: the East-West Corridor connects Silchar and Porbandar, not Dibrugarh and Surat; the Trilateral Highway is conventionally Moreh-Tamu-Kalewa-Mandalay-Myawaddy-Mae Sot, not Chiang Mai; the proposed BCIM corridor linked Kolkata and Kunming, not Varanasi. Confidence: high.

- Why this earns marks: the solution preserves ownership and key status, uses named evidence, explains significance, adds a limitation and gives a defensible conclusion or elimination route.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Historical demand preserved.
2. Current anchors do not replace the question.
3. Official, inferred and provisional key status are distinguished.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Force ownership into Topic 02.

CORRECT: Retain owner: IR Topic 02 / Geography connectivity application.

MAINS ANGLE

Revise the demand word, evidence density and status caution before writing.

STUDY LINK

Main package country/regional modules.

HIGH**PYQ 6. P2025-92 - Prelims****GS-II / Prelims**International
Relations**NEWS TRIGGER**

True owner: IR Topic 10; included here for regional architecture | Format: Objective

INTRO & ORIGIN

Consider four statements about BIMSTEC membership in January 2025, its founding declaration, founding members and sector leadership. How many are correct?

STATIC THEORY

- OFFICIAL LOCAL KEY AVAILABLE: only one statement is correct. Membership stood at seven. Nepal was not a founding member; the founding-declaration and sector-lead assertions in the paper are incorrect. India's current lead responsibility is the security pillar after sectoral reorganisation. The trap is residual memory from the older fourteen-sector structure.

- Why this earns marks: the solution preserves ownership and key status, uses named evidence, explains significance, adds a limitation and gives a defensible conclusion or elimination route.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Historical demand preserved.
2. Current anchors do not replace the question.
3. Official, inferred and provisional key status are distinguished.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Force ownership into Topic 02.

CORRECT: Retain owner: IR Topic 10; included here for regional architecture.

MAINS ANGLE

Revise the demand word, evidence density and status caution before writing.

STUDY LINK

Main package country/regional modules.

HIGH

PYQ 7. P2026-61 - Prelims

GS-II / Prelims
International
Relations

NEWS TRIGGER

True owner: IR Topic 02 | Format: Objective / provisional local key

INTRO & ORIGIN

India's cross-border bridges with Bangladesh, Myanmar and Nepal: match the named bridges or links with their partner country and location.

STATIC THEORY

- PROVISIONAL-KEY CAUTION. The local 2026 routing ledger confirms the question and a provisional Set-A key, but deliberately does not record an answer letter. Solve by mapping each bridge to the river, border state and partner; do not infer from a project name alone. This package preserves the provisional status rather than upgrading it to an official key.
- Why this earns marks: the solution preserves ownership and key status, uses named evidence, explains significance, adds a limitation and gives a defensible conclusion or elimination route.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Historical demand preserved.
2. Current anchors do not replace the question.
3. Official, inferred and provisional key status are distinguished.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Force ownership into Topic 02.

CORRECT: Retain owner: IR Topic 02.

MAINS ANGLE

Revise the demand word, evidence density and status caution before writing.

STUDY LINK

Main package country/regional modules.

HIGH

PYQ 8. P2026-67 - Prelims

GS-II / Prelims
International
Relations

NEWS TRIGGER

True owner: IR Topic 02 | Format: Objective / provisional local key

INTRO & ORIGIN

Indian development-assistance projects matched with neighbouring partner countries and locations.

STATIC THEORY

- PROVISIONAL-KEY CAUTION. The local routing ledger confirms the demand and a provisional key but records no final answer. The correct method is a country-project-location matrix: verify the project is delivered or under implementation, distinguish grants from credit, and reject pairs that shift a known project to an adjacent country.
- Why this earns marks: the solution preserves ownership and key status, uses named evidence, explains significance, adds a limitation and gives a defensible conclusion or elimination route.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Historical demand preserved.
2. Current anchors do not replace the question.
3. Official, inferred and provisional key status are distinguished.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Force ownership into Topic 02.**CORRECT:** Retain owner: IR Topic 02.**MAINS ANGLE**

Revise the demand word, evidence density and status caution before writing.

STUDY LINK

Main package country/regional modules.

HIGH**MCQ 1. Neighbourhood Precision**

Prelims GS-I
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which statement best defines asymmetric interdependence in India's neighbourhood?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	India's greater aggregate capability coexists with mutual dependence and neighbour bargaining agency.
B	India and each neighbour possess equal bargaining power.
C	Smaller neighbours cannot diversify partners.
D	Geography removes domestic politics from bilateral relations.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: A.

- Asymmetry changes bargaining conditions; it does not eliminate interdependence or small-state agency.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: A

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE**

The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.

STUDY LINK

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 2. Neighbourhood Precision**

Prelims GS-I
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

The Gujral Doctrine is most closely associated with:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	A treaty alliance for collective defence.
B	Non-reciprocal accommodation of smaller neighbours alongside non-interference and peaceful bilateralism.
C	Uniform reciprocity from every neighbour.
D	Replacing bilateral relations with SAARC.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: B.

- Its distinctive principle is non-reciprocity toward smaller neighbours, not alliance or institutional substitution.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: B

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by rhetorical familiarity.

CORRECT: Check legal/project status and country mapping.

MAINS ANGLE

The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.

STUDY LINK

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH

MCQ 3. Neighbourhood Precision

Prelims GS-I
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which status description is accurate?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	An MoU proves a project is operational.
B	A Line of Credit proves full disbursement.
C	A commissioned asset is stronger delivery evidence than a signed vision document.
D	FTA Terms of Reference constitute a concluded FTA.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: C.

- The evidence ladder runs from intention and financing toward actual commissioning and sustained service.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: C

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 4. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Regarding the India-China boundary, which is correct?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Every WMCC meeting settles the boundary.
B	The 1993 agreement converted the LAC into a settled boundary.
C	Economic engagement proves border peace is irrelevant.
D	The LAC is not the same as a mutually agreed international boundary.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: D.

- The LAC is a border-management concept; the boundary question remains unresolved.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: D

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 5. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

India's decision of 23 April 2025 described the Indus Waters Treaty as:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Held in abeyance subject to India's stated security condition.
B	Automatically terminated by the World Bank.
C	Replaced by the Simla Agreement.
D	Converted into a SAARC instrument.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: A.

- Use the exact official phrase and do not upgrade abeyance to termination.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: A

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by rhetorical familiarity.

CORRECT: Check legal/project status and country mapping.

MAINS ANGLE

The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.

STUDY LINK

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH

MCQ 6. Neighbourhood Precision

Prelims GS-I
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which case best demonstrates legal and political dispute settlement with Bangladesh?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Unresolved Teesta negotiations alone.
B	Land Boundary Agreement implementation and acceptance of maritime adjudication.
C	Migration rhetoric.
D	Suspension of all connectivity.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: B.

- These are named examples of difficult disputes managed through agreement, constitutional implementation and adjudication.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: B

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 7. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The strongest current status statement on Kaladan is:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	The entire corridor is fully seamless.
B	Only an MoU exists.
C	The waterway and Sittwe Port are operationalised, while the road component has lagged.
D	The project was abandoned.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: C.

- This is a classic partial-delivery case requiring segment-level status language.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: C

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 8. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Why is Nepal's open border analytically important?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	It makes treaties unnecessary.
B	It removes sovereignty concerns.
C	It is identical to India's Myanmar border.
D	It produces benefits and management challenges simultaneously.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: D.

- Open borders need facilitation, labour protection and security cooperation, not binary celebration or securitisation.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: D

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by rhetorical familiarity.

CORRECT: Check legal/project status and country mapping.

MAINS ANGLE

The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.

STUDY LINK

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH

MCQ 9. Neighbourhood Precision

Prelims GS-I
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

The 2007 India-Bhutan treaty evolution is best understood as:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	A mature partnership reflecting sovereign agency and cooperation on national interests.
B	A return to colonial control.
C	Termination of development cooperation.
D	A multilateral security pact.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: A.

- The revision modernised the relationship and removed outdated guidance language.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: A

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 10. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which is the best first-responder evidence?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	A summit photograph.
B	Rapid multi-instrument support to Sri Lanka during the 2022 crisis.
C	A proposed corridor map.
D	A future completion target.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: B.

- First-responder credibility rests on delivered assistance under time pressure.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: B

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 11. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which statement on Afghanistan is correct?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Embassy status automatically equals recognition.
B	Humanitarian contact is legally impossible without recognition.
C	The 2025 Embassy upgrade and formal recognition are distinct questions.
D	India ended all engagement after 2021.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: C.
- Mission level, engagement and recognition must be kept separate.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: C

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by rhetorical familiarity.

CORRECT: Check legal/project status and country mapping.

MAINS ANGLE

The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.

STUDY LINK

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 12. Neighbourhood Precision**

Prelims GS-I
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

BIMSTEC's Charter entered into force on:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	30 March 2022.
B	16 May 2026.
C	1 January 2025.
D	20 May 2024.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: D.
- It was signed in 2022 and entered into force in 2024; the 2026 date concerns the maritime transport agreement.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: D

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 13. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Why should China-linked projects in neighbouring states not be described only as encirclement?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Neighbouring states exercise agency and seek finance, infrastructure and bargaining options.
B	External powers have no strategic effects.
C	All projects are military bases.
D	India has no policy response.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: A.

- Agency does not erase strategic effects; it changes the analysis from chessboard determinism to competitive state choice.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: A

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 14. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which legal-category distinction is correct?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	All cross-border movers are refugees.
B	Refugees, asylum seekers, undocumented migrants and internally displaced persons are distinct.
C	Undocumented migrant and asylum seeker are synonyms.
D	Citizenship follows automatically from long residence.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: B.

- Legal categories shape rights, jurisdiction and policy; rhetorical mixing causes analytical error.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: B

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by rhetorical familiarity.

CORRECT: Check legal/project status and country mapping.

MAINS ANGLE

The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.

STUDY LINK

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH

MCQ 15. Neighbourhood Precision

Prelims GS-I
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

The most credible neighbourhood implementation strategy is:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Announce more projects than partners can absorb.
B	Centralise decisions without border-state consultation.
C	Consult, deliver, communicate status honestly, maintain assets and review outcomes.
D	Measure success by summit frequency.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: C.

- Trust follows repeatable delivery and sensitivity rather than declaration volume.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: C

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 16. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The relationship between IR Topic 01 and Topic 02 is:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	They are identical packages.
B	Topic 02 owns the complete history of non-alignment.
C	Topic 01 owns all country detail.
D	Topic 01 supplies interest-instrument-status vocabulary; Topic 02 applies it without reteaching the full theory.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: D.

- This controls duplication while preserving the foundation cross-link.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: D

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 17. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which statement best captures Bangladesh's current water-diplomacy position?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	The 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty approaches its December 2026 endpoint while Teesta remains unresolved.
B	Teesta has been finally settled.
C	All shared rivers are governed by one regional treaty.
D	Water has no Indian federal dimension.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: A.
- The two rivers have different legal statuses, and federal consultation is central to Teesta.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: A

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by rhetorical familiarity.

CORRECT: Check legal/project status and country mapping.

MAINS ANGLE

The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.

STUDY LINK

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH

MCQ 18. Neighbourhood Precision

Prelims GS-I
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

A demand-driven development partnership is one in which:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	India selects projects without consultation.
B	Projects follow partner priorities and move through joint design, finance, delivery and maintenance.
C	The partner must provide equal finance.
D	Every project is a grant.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: B.
- Demand-driven describes ownership and design, not one mandatory financing instrument.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: B

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 19. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which pairing is accurate?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Bhutan rail links - fully commissioned in 2025.
B	Maldives FTA - concluded by Terms of Reference.
C	Mangdechhu - a delivered hydropower example, while newer instruments require separate status checks.
D	Sri Lanka seven MoUs - all operational by signature.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: C.

- Mangdechhu illustrates delivery; the other statements upgrade pre-delivery instruments.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: C

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 20. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The best way to write about the Tamil question in India-Sri Lanka relations is to:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Treat it as resolved in 2009.
B	Ignore Indian domestic stakeholders.
C	Reduce all bilateral ties to the issue.
D	Link reconciliation, devolution, federal sensitivity and bilateral trust without operational speculation.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: D.

- A balanced answer recognises enduring reconciliation concerns while preserving the wider relationship.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: D

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by rhetorical familiarity.

CORRECT: Check legal/project status and country mapping.

MAINS ANGLE

The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.

STUDY LINK

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 21. Neighbourhood Precision**

Prelims GS-I
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

Why is a Line of Credit not equal to development delivered?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	It provides a financing envelope; appraisal, contracting, disbursement, construction and service remain separate.
B	It is always a military treaty.
C	It cannot finance infrastructure.
D	It is identical to a grant.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: A.

- Status discipline prevents a financing agreement from being presented as a completed asset.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: A

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 22. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which statement on regional electricity trade is most defensible?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	It eliminates every political dispute.
B	It can create mutual revenue and clean-energy stakes but remains exposed to pricing, ecology, hydrology and grid constraints.
C	It requires no transmission infrastructure.
D	It is relevant only to Bhutan.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: B.

- Energy interdependence creates gains and new bargaining issues simultaneously.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: B

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 23. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Regarding Myanmar, the regime-legitimacy caution requires India to:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	End all humanitarian engagement.
B	Recognise every authority controlling territory.
C	Separate pragmatic contact, humanitarian access, diplomatic presence and formal recognition.
D	Ignore border-state concerns.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: C.
- These are distinct policy and legal choices.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: C

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by rhetorical familiarity.

CORRECT: Check legal/project status and country mapping.

MAINS ANGLE

The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.

STUDY LINK

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 24. Neighbourhood Precision**

Prelims GS-I
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

A people-to-people strategy is most useful because it:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Makes treaties unnecessary.
B	Eliminates security screening.
C	Allows interference in elections.
D	Broadens relationship resilience across government changes while complementing formal diplomacy.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: D.
- Societal ties diversify the relationship's base but cannot replace state institutions.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: D

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 25. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which is the strongest dispute-safe visual practice?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Use schematic, not-to-scale networks and label them as non-cartographic.
B	Draw a precise disputed boundary from memory.
C	Assign sovereignty by colour.
D	Omit all geography.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: A.

- Schematic geography can teach systems without making an unsupported territorial claim.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: A

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 26. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

India's comparative advantage as first responder arises chiefly from:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Automatic political loyalty.
B	Proximity, deployable capacity and ability to combine diplomatic, financial, medical and logistical tools.
C	Treaty alliance obligations.
D	Exclusion of multilateral partners.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: B.

- Speed plus diverse instruments creates value; legitimacy still depends on consent and coordination.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: B

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by rhetorical familiarity.

CORRECT: Check legal/project status and country mapping.

MAINS ANGLE

The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.

STUDY LINK

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH

MCQ 27. Neighbourhood Precision

Prelims GS-I
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which future strategy best respects small-state agency?

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Demand exclusive alignment.
B	Treat every external project as hostile.
C	Offer transparent, locally useful alternatives and accept that neighbours diversify.
D	Link aid to partisan support.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: C.

- Competitive delivery is more sustainable than veto-seeking.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: C

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**MCQ 28. Neighbourhood Precision****Prelims GS-I**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

A qualitative bilateral health scorecard should examine:

KEY DATA

Option	Choice
A	Only summit frequency.
B	Only trade volume.
C	Whether the government praises India.
D	Trust, delivery, interdependence and resilience without fabricated numeric ranking.

STATIC THEORY

- Answer: D.

- Multidimensional, qualitative diagnosis avoids false precision.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rotation position: D

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by rhetorical familiarity.**CORRECT:** Check legal/project status and country mapping.**MAINS ANGLE***The same precision prevents overclaim in GS-II answers.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the relevant country or cross-cutting module.

HIGH**Mains Practice 1. 10 marks****GS-II**
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Explain why neighbour agency is indispensable to analysing China's role in South Asia.

STATIC THEORY

- Claim: China's presence affects India's security and economic interests, but neighbours are decision-makers rather than passive arenas. Evidence: Nepal, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Maldives diversify infrastructure and financing partners; India itself practices strategic autonomy. Mechanism: multiple offers increase bargaining space, while local politics, debt capacity and project utility shape choices. Qualification: agency does not make Chinese dual-use risk or opaque finance irrelevant. Verdict: India should answer through competitive delivery and transparent public goods, not exclusivity demands.

- Why this earns marks: direct thesis; named bilateral/current evidence; explanation of mechanism and significance; explicit qualification; calibrated verdict. Expand evidence density in a timed answer according to marks.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Claim -> evidence -> mechanism -> qualification -> verdict.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: List all countries.

CORRECT: Select examples that prove the argument.

MAINS ANGLE

Write within the stated word limit after reproducing the five-part spine.

STUDY LINK

Main package comparative matrix and GS-II answer spine.

HIGH**Mains Practice 2. 10 marks**

GS-II
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

Distinguish a border-management policy from a borderland-development policy.

STATIC THEORY

- Claim: management controls movement and risk; development changes the incentives and capabilities of border communities. Evidence: integrated check posts and legal trade routes complement policing; Nepal's open border and Myanmar's conflict border require different mixes. Mechanism: services, markets and connectivity reduce illicit dependence and improve state legitimacy. Qualification: development cannot replace intelligence and law enforcement at high-risk nodes. Verdict: combine smart control with locally designed economic and social infrastructure.

- Why this earns marks: direct thesis; named bilateral/current evidence; explanation of mechanism and significance; explicit qualification; calibrated verdict. Expand evidence density in a timed answer according to marks.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Claim -> evidence -> mechanism -> qualification -> verdict.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: List all countries.

CORRECT: Select examples that prove the argument.

MAINS ANGLE

Write within the stated word limit after reproducing the five-part spine.

STUDY LINK

Main package comparative matrix and GS-II answer spine.

HIGH

Mains Practice 3. 15 marksGS-II
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Structural asymmetry, rather than goodwill, is the defining condition of India's relations with smaller neighbours. Critically examine.

STATIC THEORY

- Claim: asymmetry is the starting condition, not a predetermined outcome. Evidence: Gujral Doctrine non-reciprocity, Bhutan's demand-driven plan support, Nepal power trade, Sri Lanka crisis response and Maldives first-responder cases show how capability can provide public goods. Mechanism: consultation and non-reciprocity convert scale into reassurance. Qualification: project delay, sovereignty narratives, federal disputes and external-power options can convert the same asymmetry into dependence anxiety. Verdict: goodwill matters only when institutionalised through sensitivity, delivery and neighbour agency.

- Why this earns marks: direct thesis; named bilateral/current evidence; explanation of mechanism and significance; explicit qualification; calibrated verdict. Expand evidence density in a timed answer according to marks.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Claim -> evidence -> mechanism -> qualification -> verdict.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: List all countries.

CORRECT: Select examples that prove the argument.

MAINS ANGLE

Write within the stated word limit after reproducing the five-part spine.

STUDY LINK

Main package comparative matrix and GS-II answer spine.

HIGH

Mains Practice 4. 15 marksGS-II
International
Relations**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Water diplomacy is the hardest test of Neighbourhood First. Discuss.

STATIC THEORY

- Claim: water combines finite seasonal flows, sovereignty, federal politics, ecology and security. Evidence: the Indus Treaty abeyance position, the Ganga Treaty's December 2026 endpoint, unresolved Teesta and Nepal river mechanisms represent different legal stages. Mechanism: data sharing, flood warning and joint institutions create repeated cooperation. Qualification: technical institutions cannot eliminate terrorism, domestic federal vetoes or climate uncertainty. Verdict: basin science plus political consultation is superior to either hydro-hegemony or sentimental generosity.

- Why this earns marks: direct thesis; named bilateral/current evidence; explanation of mechanism and significance; explicit qualification; calibrated verdict. Expand evidence density in a timed answer according to marks.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Claim -> evidence -> mechanism -> qualification -> verdict.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: List all countries.

CORRECT: Select examples that prove the argument.

MAINS ANGLE

Write within the stated word limit after reproducing the five-part spine.

STUDY LINK

Main package comparative matrix and GS-II answer spine.

HIGH**Mains Practice 5. 15 marks**

GS-II
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

Evaluate connectivity as both an economic instrument and a strategic credibility test in India's neighbourhood.

STATIC THEORY

- Claim: corridors convert proximity into trade and influence only when operational end to end. Evidence: Akhaura-Agartala is inaugurated; Kaladan is partially operational; the Trilateral Highway remains incomplete; Bhutan rail links are under an MoU; BBIN is constrained by ratification. Mechanism: roads, ports, power and customs create markets and interdependence. Qualification: conflict, maintenance, border procedures and local opposition can strand assets. Verdict: audit use and service quality, not just construction.

- Why this earns marks: direct thesis; named bilateral/current evidence; explanation of mechanism and significance; explicit qualification; calibrated verdict. Expand evidence density in a timed answer according to marks.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Claim -> evidence -> mechanism -> qualification -> verdict.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: List all countries.

CORRECT: Select examples that prove the argument.

MAINS ANGLE

Write within the stated word limit after reproducing the five-part spine.

STUDY LINK

Main package comparative matrix and GS-II answer spine.

HIGH**Mains Practice 6. 20 marks**

GS-II
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

India's neighbourhood policy must move from regime-oriented engagement to society-oriented partnership. Analyse with country examples.

STATIC THEORY

- Claim: political transitions repeatedly expose the fragility of ties concentrated in incumbents. Evidence: recent transitions in Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka and Maldives; Sikri's prescription; open-border social links with Nepal; development goodwill in Afghanistan; Tamil and fishermen issues in Sri Lanka. Mechanism: universities, health, labour channels, local bodies and transparent projects diversify the relationship's domestic base. Qualification: governments remain necessary for treaties, security and finance; society outreach cannot bypass sovereignty. Verdict: institution-plus-society engagement best survives electoral cycles.

- Why this earns marks: direct thesis; named bilateral/current evidence; explanation of mechanism and significance; explicit qualification; calibrated verdict. Expand evidence density in a timed answer according to marks.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Claim -> evidence -> mechanism -> qualification -> verdict.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: List all countries.

CORRECT: Select examples that prove the argument.

MAINS ANGLE

Write within the stated word limit after reproducing the five-part spine.

STUDY LINK

Main package comparative matrix and GS-II answer spine.

HIGH**Mains Practice 7. 20 marks**

GS-II
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

Design a differentiated Neighbourhood First strategy for continental, Himalayan, eastern and maritime neighbours.

STATIC THEORY

- Claim: one slogan needs country-specific instruments. Evidence: Pakistan requires deterrence and crisis communication; China needs border stability and de-risking; Nepal/Bhutan need open-border, power and development cooperation; Bangladesh/Myanmar need Northeast connectivity and humane borders; Sri Lanka/Maldives need maritime public goods and political sensitivity; Afghanistan needs pragmatic humanitarian contact. Mechanism: differentiation aligns tools with geography and partner incentives. Qualification: regional institutions still provide common rules and reassurance. Verdict: differentiated bilateralism nested in functional regionalism.

- Why this earns marks: direct thesis; named bilateral/current evidence; explanation of mechanism and significance; explicit qualification; calibrated verdict. Expand evidence density in a timed answer according to marks.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Claim -> evidence -> mechanism -> qualification -> verdict.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: List all countries.

CORRECT: Select examples that prove the argument.

MAINS ANGLE

Write within the stated word limit after reproducing the five-part spine.

STUDY LINK

Main package comparative matrix and GS-II answer spine.

HIGH

Comparative Country Case Exercises

GS-II
International
Relations

INTRO & ORIGIN

Case 1: compare Nepal and Bangladesh on connectivity plus domestic politics. Case 2: compare Sri Lanka and Maldives on maritime public goods plus sovereignty narratives. Case 3: compare Pakistan and China on crisis management, boundary status and economic exposure. Case 4: compare Myanmar and Afghanistan on regime-legitimacy caution, humanitarian engagement and access constraints.

COMPARATIVE PYQ AND ANSWER SPINE

Country Answer Templates and GS-II Spine

Opening	Evidence	Analysis	Close
- Interest - Partner agency - Current status	- Named instrument - Exact status/date - Country example	- Mechanism - Significance - Comparison	- Limitation - Calibrated strategy - Verdict

Claim -> evidence -> mechanism -> qualification -> verdict.

Use common criteria rather than country listing.

Original deterministic study visual.

STATIC THEORY

- For each case, write a two-column evidence matrix: interest; partner incentive; named instrument; exact status; implementation constraint; people-to-people link; China/external-power effect; calibrated verdict.

- Model route: begin with the shared criterion, then contrast the mechanism. Nepal-Bangladesh connectivity differs because Nepal is open-border and power-led while Bangladesh is transit, port and river-linked. Sri Lanka-Maldives differ in population, fishermen/Tamil issues and archipelagic vulnerability. Pakistan-China differ in trade exposure and institutional engagement even though both carry security disputes.

- Why this earns marks: comparison is controlled by a common variable and avoids unrelated country fact-dumping.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Comparison requires a common criterion.
2. Every row needs a limitation.
3. Name one dated bilateral instrument for each country.
4. Separate partner agency from the external-power effect.
5. Close with a comparative verdict rather than two unrelated conclusions.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Write two separate mini-essays.

CORRECT: Compare point by point.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the qualitative relationship scorecard; never fabricate a numeric ranking.

STUDY LINK

Country dashboard and final register notes.